



# BREWING UP A STORM

Puja Tomar, aka The Cyclone, became the **first Indian MMA fighter** to win in the UFC.

**Nigamanth P**

nigamanth.p@thehindu.co.in

**M**any trained, many tried, and almost all of them failed when it mattered most, except for a certain 30-year-old.

Puja Tomar (**above, in green**) defied the odds to become the first-ever Indian MMA fighter to register a win in the UFC (Ultimate Fighting Championship). 'The Cyclone' achieved this milestone at UFC Louisville, securing a **split-decision victory over Brazil's Rayanne dos Santos in the strawweight division a couple of weeks ago.**

Such is the pressure that a stage like the UFC puts on an athlete. But Puja saw it differently. "Looking at it as a fight didn't put me under any pressure. But I had this constant rage to win it, at least for the flag I represent. I've seen a lot of fights like this and have won championships. But I felt a slight pressure to win it for India," she said.

The UFC win is just another feather in Puja's cap. **She turned heads with her technique in the ONE Championship and went on to participate in the Matrix Fight Night,** a promotion founded by Bollywood actor Tiger Shroff.

The Uttar Pradesh-born fighter climbed the ranks and tasted success by winning the strawweight title bout against the USA's Bi Nguyen. She then defended her title via knockout against Russia's Anastasia Feofanova, and that is when the UFC came knocking on her door.

When asked about her journey to the UFC, she explained, "I knew when MFN was started, there would be a steady rise in MMA's popularity in India. MFN was the promotion that kicked off my career. Yes, I started to fight to get financially stable, but MFN provided a lot more than financial stability, and evidently, my career took off."

**But her road to the top has been filled with challenges,** starting with the scarce opportunities for women

in combat sports as compared to the male fighters.

"Getting validation from my family was the most difficult part. If it were boxing, it would've been different since people know about the sport, but MMA is different. They didn't want me to get injuries or cuts on my face. My mom was my only support system." Puja said.

**Puja lost her dad at a very young age. To help her mother make ends meet, she worked on their farm, which helped improve her endurance.**

"I didn't expect that it would make me stronger. I went on to participate and win the National Wushu Championship. So I guess all the *ghee* I ate and the milk I drank helped me become stronger and made me who I am today," she said.

Puja isn't certain when she will enter the octagon next in the UFC, but there is one thing she is confident of — clinching the championship belt and bringing glory to India.